ISS 325: War and Revolution
Summer 2026 – Session #2
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I. Course Personnel

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II. Course Description

Video Games and Conflict. Good versus evil. Us versus them. Player 1 versus Player 2. This section explores what video games can tell us about a variety of aspects of social, political, economic, and military conflicts in society. Students will play video games to experience what this important and influential medium tells us about conflict in the 21st century. Some experience with video games will be useful but not necessary. Bring a friend: this class will also support cooperative learning through team and collaborative gaming.

III. Course Materials

You will be playing several video games for this course. The module descriptions below identifies what those games are and what platforms they are available. Note that both the MSU Computer Store and Book Store stock a variety of video game consoles and accessories. We will be using Desire2Learn (hereafter D2L) as our online course management software. The website is https://d2L.msu.edu. You will be able to access course lectures, readings, assignments, and your grades on D2L. Any problems you encounter with D2L should be reported to MSU's Distance Learning Service. Their telephone numbers are located at the top of this syllabus. Do not– we repeat, do not – seek tech support from any other source beyond their telephone number. We are unable to provide support and although you can submit an electronic request, it will take much longer to receive a response.

IV. Course Requirements

Everyone is required to complete an initial module that introduces some important foundational and general material about video games and "conflict." Successful completion of this module will require that you watch a couple of documentaries, do some readings, and play an independent game. You will then do a few short quizzes and answer some "diary" questions (see more on this below).

After completing this module, you will choose 3 thematic modules from a set of options. For each of these modules, you will do a number of tasks: Play video games, study background materials, take quizzes covering the game play and background materials, and, finally, do some writing that combines your experience playing the games with background materials.

Background Quizzes

You will complete timed quizzes for both the introductory and game playing-based modules. Each quiz will have between 10 and 20 questions on it. The purpose of the quizzes is to allow you to demonstrate that you have learned the assigned reading material. After your first attempt at the quiz you will see what questions you got wrong (but not the answers for those questions). You will then have a chance to go back and complete as many additional attempts at the entire quiz if you so desire. Your quiz grade for that module will be the highest of your attempts. For example, if you took a quiz twice and initially scored 70% and then scored 90% on your second try, then your recorded score would be 90%.

Writing Diaries

The second broad area consists of what I'm calling "writing diaries." These diaries are not research papers but rather provide you with a chance to reflect upon what you have learned and demonstrate that you can see connections between your game playing and the course materials. You will complete one diary for both the introductory module and each of the three gaming-based modules. Once your diary submissions have been graded, in addition to a score for each question, we will also provide an individual score for each category on the rubric. This lets you see where your response was assessed as being not entirely at the standard required for the assignment.

V. Student Evaluation and Grading

Point Values

You will do one introductory module and then three game-based modules. For each module you will be responsible for completing quizzes and a writing diary. Background quizzes for each module are worth a total of 50 points, which will be evenly divided across however many quizzes you are to take, and each writing diary is worth 150 points. Thus, each module is worth 200 points. There are four modules, so that's 800 points overall for our course.

Grading Scale

Point Range	Grade Earned
720-800	4.0
696-719	3.5
640-695	3.0
616-639	2.5
560-615	2.0
536-559	1.5
480-535	1.0
0-479	0

VI. Course Policies and Procedures

General Statement

You are responsible for informing yourself of all relevant departmental, college, and university policies governing your conduct in this course. This includes, but is not limited to, policies relating to plagiarism/academic integrity and the accommodation of students with documented disabilities.

Late Penalties

To be eligible to receive full credit, all assignments must be submitted prior to their respective deadlines. The "Course Calendar" below provides these deadlines. It is your responsibility to ensure that all assignments are submitted in a timely manner. Technology issues (e.g., computer and/or internet access failure) are not acceptable excuses and you should ensure that you leave enough of a time "buffer" to anticipate, address, and resolve any such issues. The only exception to this will be a complete and prolonged outage of D2L during the time immediately before when an assignment is due. Late assignments will be accepted and graded but with late penalties imposed. See the reading diary assignment guidelines for specific values.

Course Communications

We will send out occasional updates and notices via our course's D2L page. You are strongly encouraged to alter your D2L settings so that you will be emailed and/or texted whenever news announcements are posted. To do so, log in to D2L, click your name in the top right part of the screen, and then select "Notifications." We suggest checking the boxes for "News – item updated" and "News – new item available."

Grade Appeals

If you have a question or concern regarding your performance on a quiz or assignment, you should begin by reviewing the grading rubric and feedback provided. If that does not clarify the issues, then you should contact us via the course email account. Except for arithmetic errors in calculating your score, all concerns must be submitted via email and should concisely expresses why you believe your grade should be altered. Note that we only grade based on what you have submitted in your assignment. If your grade challenge includes language clarifying what you meant to say in your

response, you are simply wasting your time/energy. Your grade will be unchanged. The only grade appeals that tend to be successful are those that point out where you included information that we thought you did not include. That is, there was a basic mistake on the part of the grader. Given the size of our class and the number of items to be graded, such innocent mistakes will occur from time to time. And we'll fix them if you point them out to us. All concerns – arithmetic or otherwise – must be raised within one week of when the assignment/quiz grade was posted. After this one-week period, no grade challenges will be entertained.

Academic Honesty

Part 2.III.B.2 of the document "Student Rights and Responsibilities" reads: "The student shares with the faculty the responsibility for maintaining the integrity of scholarship, grades, and professional standards." In addition, the Political Science Department adheres to the policies on academic honesty specified in General Student Regulation 1.0, Protection of Scholarship and Grades; the all-University Policy on Integrity of Scholarship and Grades; and Ordinance 17.00, Examinations. In ISS 325, academic dishonesty is defined as conduct that violates these principles: (a) supplying or using work or answers that are not one's own; (b) providing or accepting assistance with completing assignments or examinations; or (c) interfering through any means with another's academic work. Please note: if you study together, be sure that you do not submit verbatim or near-verbatim answers to assignments. To do so violates both the spirit and the letter of academic integrity. It is imperative that the work you turn in is your own work – even if you study together and jointly prepare assignments. The penalties for dishonesty will vary from getting 0 points on an individual assignment up to getting a 0.0 grade for the entire semester. Consistent with MSU's policy regarding penalty grades, all instances of academic dishonesty will be reported to the Office of the Registrar and your college.

Extra Credit

You can earn up to 75 points of extra credit by completing the diary questions for a 4th gaming module. All you need to do is pick a 4th module, do the associated reading and game playing, and then answer the diary questions for that module. You do not – and should not – do the quizzes. You will not get extra credit for that. You only get extra credit for doing the diary questions. Submit your diary responses into the assignment labelled "Extra Credit" on D2L. Make sure you remember to specify what module you are doing in the file name! This is just as critical as it is for a regular assignment! We will grade your answers just like we would a normal diary submission. Once we have calculated your overall score out of 150 points, we will then divide it by 2. This is because the extra credit has a maximum value of 75 points. Thus, if you were to get 110 out of 150 points, your total extra credit earned would be 55 points (if it's a fraction we'll always round up to the next highest whole number). The points that we add will go towards your diary grades. The same deadline applies to the extra credit module as does Module #3 (see "Course Calendar" below).

Syllabus Adjustments and Tweaks

We reserve the right to make modifications to this syllabus and the course schedule as necessary to account for the unique dynamics of our class. If changes are made, they will be announced on the D2L site.

VII. Course Calendar

All work is due no later than 11:59 pm EDT on the date listed below. Late work is accepted but will be penalized as indicated above.

	Completion Deadline
Introduction Module	July 12
Gaming Module #1	July 23
Gaming Module #2	August 2
Gaming Module #3	August 13

VIII. Gaming Modules

Beyond the required introduction module described earlier, you need to complete 3 out of the following modules. You get to pick which 3 modules you'd like to do, and you can complete them in any order you like. The information below identifies the modules, provides a short description of each, and lists the games that you can choose from to complete the module. If you have any questions or want some thoughts about what we think you might like, please don't hesitate to drop us a line –we'd be happy to give our advice.

Animal Welfare

This module examines the deep entanglement between human nature and non-human life. An overlooked aspect of armed conflict is the threat it poses to environments and their surrounding biodiversity's. Wars negatively impact natural resources, destroy habitats, increase pollution and displace wildlife. The open-world nature and unique story plots of these games provide a meaningful illustration of systemic environmental conflict, highlighting how societies negotiate power often at the expense of dominating ecosystems. Moreover, these games engage in philosophical and ethical considerations of coexisting with or domesticating animals.

Game Options (choose one)
Shelter 2
Endling: Extinction is Forever
Pokémon Black & White 2 (or Omega Ruby & Alpha Saphire)

Crime

Criminal activity, while taboo in society, is often celebrated in pop culture. Take your place on either side of the criminal/law enforcement divide in this module with some of the most immersive crime experiences available on console. Choose among a diverse selection of games ranging from organized crime in the pursuit of the American Dream to expansive, open worlds that complicate the gamer's understanding of moral binaries in broader structures of race, class and state power.

Game Options (choose one)
Grand Theft Auto V
Mafia II: Definitive Edition
Red Dead Redemption 2

Cyberwarfare, AI and the Digital Age

Cyberwarfare is one of the most pressing yet least understood aspects of modern conflict. As a player, you will get an inside look at tech infrastructure and its intersections with digital and information warfare. Common themes explored in these games include coding operations, drone surveillance, infiltration and computer hacking—among other frontiers. Naturally, this module equally invites critical questions about ethics and civilian resistance, underlining how fast-evolving technology comes clashes with matters like security and privacy rights.

Game Options (choose one)
Cyber Ops
Cyberpunk 2077
Watch Dogs: Legion

Democracy v. Authoritarianism

Worldwide, the rate of democratic nations is trending downward while the number of authoritarian regimes continue to rise. This module explores the origins, structures and strategies autocratic rulers use to undermine democratic governance. If you go the dictator route, these games will grant you the ability to use tactics such as propaganda, state surveillance, absolute economic control and even dabble in electoral politics to learn how elected officials establish and maintain political power. These games also offer an opportunity to engage in diplomacy with other nations as well as aligning yourself with and against competing factions at home.

Game Options (choose one)
Tropico 6
Suzerain
Frostpunk 2

International Relations

This module provides an introduction to divergent topics in international relations studies and war. Unlike many modern war-centric games that glamorize conflict, the games here provide deep, realistic insight into the horrors of war, providing both international and civil perspectives on and off the battleground. They also showcase some theory behind how and why wars begin, entrenched in enthralling and detailed narratives.

Required Game (all must play)
Valiant Hearts: The Great War

Game Options (choose one)
Metal Gear Solid V: The Phantom Pain
This War of Mine
Call of Duty: Modern Warfare 2
Ghost of Tsushima

Multiplayer

Many modern games focus on competitive multiplayer, but the gaming industry also features a healthy number of cooperative multiplayer games. In this module, you and another person will play through intense, cooperative adventures. In Lethal Company, for example, you must collect scrap in abandoned moons to meet profit quotas as you fend off aliens. Meanwhile, in Split Fiction you will explore dystopian, split screen worlds filled with fast-paced and tactical decision-making mechanics. We strongly recommend having a second player – classmate, roommate, significant other, whoever – available for this module.

Game Options
Lethal Company
Marvel Rivals
Split Fiction (if **1 person** owns the game, **2 people** can play it)

Outer Space

While still in its infancy, space warfare is poised to become a critical frontier in modern conflict. Global superpowers continue to develop space weaponry and expand their orbital reach, with all signs pointing to warfare that will extend beyond the Earth's atmosphere. This module invites you to reckon with the implications of technology, sovereignty and human survival. Some games situate the theme of outer space through a speculative fiction lens while others offer a more political realist view of galactic diplomacy.

Game Options (choose one)
Mass Effect 1, 2 or 3 (*Mass Effect: Legendary Edition* recommended)
Star Wars: Squadrons
Endless Space 2
Halo Reach or ODST
Star Wars: Renegade Squadron (a 2007 game but its immersive galactic conquest mode is worthy of play)

Superheroes

Historically, superheroes have been represented as unique individuals with extraordinary powers who confront complicated narratives of legitimacy and power. Because of this, fantasy fiction has created a variety of characters that respond to societal failures. Yet, superheroes often face moral dilemmas that complicate their roles. As a result, they can reproduce power structures and uphold status quos just as easily as they can subvert them. After playing through the games, you will read about the role of antiheroes in fiction. If you are interested in urban decay and gritty portrayals of corruption, then *Batman: Arkham City* is a fine choice. For those interested in exploring themes of grief and community resilience then may we suggest *Spider-Man: Miles Morales*.

Game Options (choose one)
Batman: Arkham City
Marvel's Guardians of the Galaxy
Spider-Man: Miles Morales
Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice

World Building

Imagine and design worlds through these simulation games. In this module, you will step into the role of creator—crafting vibrant cities, building farmlands and shaping individual lives. Build civilian infrastructure, manage labor, and address community needs—in other words, manage the mundane institutions that help prevent conflict from happening in the first place. As you play, consider how the in-game mechanics help explain the real-world strategies of policymaking, city designing, profitmaking, innovation and civilian life to our world.

Game Options (choose one)
Anno 1800
Cities: Skylines II
Farming Simulator 25
Sims 4